

Lesson 9: “The Only True and Living Church” (See [Class Member Study Guide](#))

Purpose: To help us learn about the restoration of the Church of Jesus Christ through the Prophet Joseph Smith, to help us appreciate the blessings of Church membership, and to encourage us to show the Lord our gratitude for membership in His Church.

‘Build Up My Church’: Historical context of sections 20 and 21 of the Doctrine and Covenants.

1. The Church is organized in the latter days.

- Isaiah 11:11-12 and 29:13-14; Daniel 2:44-45; 1 Nephi 14:12-14 **†1.** Fulfilling the ancient prophecies
- D&C 20:1 and D&C 21:3 On what date was the Church organized in this dispensation? Why was this date selected? (see the heading to D&C 20.)

• Ten years passed between the First Vision and the organization of the Church. During this time, what events occurred to prepare the way for the organization of the Church and to prepare Joseph Smith to lead it? **†2.** President Gordon B. Hinckley **†3.** April 6, 1830 **†4.** The name of the Church

2. The Lord commands Church members to follow the prophet. ([D&C 21](#))

• D&C 1:38 and 21:4-5 “[W]hether by mine own voice or by the voice of my servants, it is the same.” What counsel or teachings of latter-day prophets have been especially meaningful to you?

• D&C 21:5 “For his word ye shall receive, as if from mine own mouth, in all patience and faith.” When has following the prophet’s counsel required your patience or faith?

• D&C 21:6 “For by doing these things the gates of hell shall not prevail against you”. What are some ways you have been blessed because you have followed the prophet?

• D&C 21:9 “For, behold, I will bless all those who labor in my vineyard with a mighty blessing”. How have you been blessed as you have served the Lord? **†5.** President Ezra Taft Benson

3. The Lord encourages Church members to meet together often to partake of the sacrament.

Why do you think it was important to have the ordinance of the sacrament performed at that first meeting?

• D&C 20:75-79 Why is it important to partake of the sacrament often? (See verse 75)

†6. Elder Melvin K. Ballard

What covenants do we make by partaking of the sacrament? (See also D&C 20:37 and Mosiah 18:8-10.)

What does it mean to remember Him always? How does the sacrament help us remember Him?

What does the Lord promise us? How has partaking of the sacrament blessed your life?

• D&C 27:2-4 What was Joseph doing when he received this revelation?

How can we partake of the sacrament “with an eye single to [Christ’s] glory”?

4. The Lord explains the duties of Church members.

• D&C 20:68-69 What does verse 69 reveal about the Lord’s expectations of us as Church members?

Conclusion.

“[T]he organization of the Church of Jesus Christ in 1830 was one of the great miracles of the latter days. Even though that small meeting in Fayette, New York, went unnoticed by most people, the events of that day have changed the world.” (*Lesson Manual*)

Please “reflect on the miracle of the Church’s worldwide growth from such humble beginnings.”

†7. President Wilford Woodruff

Next Week: Lesson 10: “This Is My Voice unto All”; See L10 [Class Member Study Guide](#). † •
(You can download a free LDS Institute Manual at: [Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325](#).)

†1. **Fulfilling the ancient prophecies:** “1830 was a momentous time in the history of the world. The time had come for ancient prophecies to be fulfilled... After the Book of Mormon was published and the priesthood was restored, the next major step in the restoration of the gospel was the formal organization of the Church.” (*Lesson Manual*)

†2. **President Gordon B. Hinckley:** “This day of organization was, in effect, a day of commencement, the graduation for Joseph from ten years of remarkable schooling. It had begun with the incomparable vision in the grove in the spring of 1820, when the Father and the Son appeared to the fourteen-year-old boy. It had continued with the tutoring from Moroni, with both warnings and instructions given on multiple occasions. Then there was the translation of the ancient record, and the inspiration, the knowledge, the revelation that came from that experience. There was the bestowal of divine authority ... There were revelations ... All of these were preliminary to that historic April 6” (“[150-Year Drama: A Personal View of Our History](#),” *Ensign*, Apr. 1980, 11-12).

†3. **April 6, 1830:** “On 6 April 1830, Joseph Smith and more than 50 other people met at the log home of Peter Whitmer Sr. in Fayette, New York, for the organization of the Church. New York law required that a church have at least six members to be formally organized. So [six men, all of whom had been baptized and had seen the gold plates](#), became the first official members of the Church. These men were Joseph Smith, Oliver Cowdery, Hyrum Smith, Peter Whitmer Jr., Samuel H. Smith, and David Whitmer (see *History of the Church*, 1:76; for additional historical background, see [Our Heritage](#), pages 14-16).

†4. **The name of the Church.** D&C 20:1 identifies the Church’s name as the Church of Christ. “The Church was also called by other names in its early years, but in April 1838 the Lord revealed the name by which His Church was to be known. What name did the Lord give His Church? (See [D&C 115:4](#).) Why is it important that the Lord’s Church be called in His name? (See [3 Nephi 27:8](#).) (*Lesson Manual*)

†5. **President Ezra Taft Benson:** “Third: *The living prophet is more important to us than a dead one.* “God’s revelation to Adam did not instruct Noah how to build the Ark. Noah needed his own revelation. Therefore the most important prophet so far as you and I are concerned is the one living in our day and age to whom the Lord is currently revealing His will for us. Therefore the most important reading we can do is any of the words of the prophet contained each month in our Church Magazines. Our instructions about what we

should do for each six months are found in the General Conference addresses...

“Beware of those who would set up the dead prophets against the living prophets, for the living prophets always take precedence.” (“[Fourteen Fundamentals in Following the Prophet](#),” *Liahona*, June 1981, 1)

†6. **Elder Melvin J. Ballard:** “No man goes away from this Church and becomes an apostate in a week, nor in a month. It is a slow process. [The one thing that would make for the safety of every man and woman would be to appear at the sacrament table every Sabbath day.](#) We would not get very far away in a week—not so far away that, by the process of self-investigation, we could not rectify the wrongs we may have done. If we should refrain from partaking of the sacrament, condemned by ourselves as unworthy to receive these emblems, we could not endure that long, and we would soon, I am sure, have the spirit of repentance. [The road to the sacrament table is the path of safety for Latter-day Saints.](#)” (*Improvement Era*, Oct 1919, p. 1028 “[The Sacramental Covenant](#),” *A sermon delivered at the M. I. A. annual conference, Sunday, June 8, 1919.)

†7. **President Wilford Woodruff** “told of a meeting in which the Prophet Joseph Smith prophesied of the Church’s growth. The meeting was in ‘a small house, perhaps 14 feet square. But it held the whole of the Priesthood of the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints who were then in the town of Kirtland, and who had gathered together to go off in Zion’s camp.’ After several of the men had borne their testimonies of the work, the Prophet said:

“... I want to say to you before the Lord, that you know no more concerning the destinies of this Church and kingdom than a babe upon its mother’s lap. You don’t comprehend it.... [It is only a little handful of priesthood you see here tonight, but this Church will fill North and South America—it will fill the world](#)” (Conference Report, Apr. 1898, 57 as cited in D&C Lesson 9: “[The Only True and Living Church](#)” Go to the Conclusion and read the second and third paragraphs.)

Recommended Reading:

President Ezra Taft Benson, “[Fourteen Fundamentals in Following the Prophet](#),” *Liahona*, June 1981, 1.

Elder Don R. Clarke, “[Blessings of the Sacrament](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 2012, 104.

Elder Scott D. Whiting, “[Temple Standard](#),” *Ensign*, Nov. 2012, 37.

[Nancy Jensen](#), D&C L9 “The Only True and Living Church.”

“[6 Reasons Why Mormons Are Beating Evangelicals in Church Growth](#),” David French.

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Further Enrichment Resources:

Historical Background.

“For over seventeen centuries the Church of Jesus Christ had been, as John the Revelator prophesied, in ‘the wilderness’ because of apostasy (Revelation 12:14; see also D&C 86), and Christ’s Church had been corrupted by the doctrines of men.

“On Tuesday, 6 April 1830, in the state of New York, a small group of people convened in the home of Peter Whitmer Sr. No heads of nations were invited to this meeting, nor were the religious leaders of the day. No newspapers heralded the events of this meeting. But in heaven the angels rejoiced, and on earth this select group, under the direction of a modern prophet, organized the Church of Jesus Christ.

“The meeting was opened by solemn prayer. Joseph Smith and Oliver Cowdery were sustained as leaders in the kingdom of God and were given unanimous approval to organize the Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints. The Prophet Joseph Smith recorded the events that ensued:

“ ‘I then laid my hands on I then laid my hands upon Oliver Cowdery, and ordained him an Elder of the ‘Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints;’ after which, he ordained me also to the office of an Elder of said Church. [Although they had been ordained to the Melchizedek Priesthood earlier, they were told to defer ordaining each other to the office of elder until the Church was organized (see *History of the Church*, 1:61).] We then took bread, blessed it, and brake it with them; also wine, blessed it, and drank it with them. We then laid our hands on each individual member of the Church present, that they might receive the gift of the Holy Ghost, and be confirmed members of the Church of Christ. The Holy Ghost was poured out upon us to a very great degree—some prophesied, whilst we all praised the Lord, and rejoiced exceedingly. Whilst yet together, I received the following commandment: [D&C 21].” (*History of the Church*, 1:77-78. [In *Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325*, p. 43. Enter page 60 in the search block of the pdf to get to the manual’s page 43.]

D&C 21:4-5. “as if from mine own mouth”

President Joseph Fielding Smith: “We are more inclined to accept as the word of the Lord something which was uttered in some former dispensation, but look with critical eye and unbelief upon that which the Lord delivers today through his chosen servants. Yet the word of the Lord is very clear on this matter. Let us not lose sight of the word of the Lord, that by hearkening to his chosen servant ... ‘The gates of hell shall not prevail against us.’” (*Church History and Modern Revelation*, 1:107-8.)

President Harold B. Lee: “There will be some things that take patience and faith. You may not like what comes from the authority of the Church. It may contradict your political views. It may contradict your social views. It may interfere with some of your social life.

“... Your safety and ours depends upon whether or not we follow the ones whom the Lord has placed to preside over his church. He knows whom he wants to preside over this church, and he will make no mistake. The Lord doesn’t do things by accident....

“Let’s keep our eye on the President of the Church.” (Conference Report, Oct. 1970, pp. 152-53)

D&C 21:7. God’s Prophet Leads the Cause of Zion—to Follow Him is the Path of Safety

Elder Delbert L. Stapley: “I bear witness to you, my brothers and sisters, that God sustains [the living prophet], and no one else in the world today but him, because he has the holy calling of prophet, seer, and revelator, representing the Lord upon the earth in our time. He only has the right to revelation for the people of the Church, and if all people would understand that, they would not be tossed about by those who would seek to divert their minds from the Church and its glorious principles....

“... They will be fortified against the false teachers and anti-Christ, and we do have them among us.” (Conference Report, Oct. 1953, p. 70.)

Elder Harold B. Lee: “We have a mouthpiece to whom God does and is revealing his mind and will. God will never permit him to lead us astray. As has been said, God would remove us out of our place if we should attempt to do it. You have no concern. Let the management and government of God, then, be with the Lord. Do not try to find fault with the management and affairs that pertain to him alone and by revelation through his prophet—his living prophet, his seer, and his revelator.” (*The Place of the Living Prophet* [address delivered to seminary and institute of religion personnel], 8 July 1964, p. 16. [In *Doctrine and Covenants Manual: Religion 324 and 325*, p. 45. In pdf search for p. 62.]

The place of the living prophet is taught in several places in the Doctrine and Covenants. Enrichment F in the Appendix contains a complete treatment of this theme.

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